happen. It did not happen and he was brutally executed by the Taliban/ said Asthana.

The Indian diplomatic mission in Kabul was closed after the Taliban takeover on 27 September 1996 and Massoud and other warriors retreated to northern Afghanistan. In an official statement, India made it clear that the situation had been further exacerbated by the direct interference of Pakistan and more so through its creation, the Taliban. The R&AW report said the Taliban militia had received the active support of Pakistan army regulars while attacking the Afghan capital. On the diplomatic front, the Indian government continued to recognise Rabbani's rule in Afghanistan but in the world of shadows, there was significant apprehension since the Taliban in early 1997 was making advances against the combined forces of the Northern Alliance consisting of Mirza, Massoud and Jaleel, the three R&AW assets. Months later Mirza found himself helpless and homeless.

Igniting the Flames

Ashfaq's meeting with Mirza that fateful day in Istanbul was a revelation about Pakistan's unflinching support to insurgents operating in Afghanistan. Mirza revealed Pakistan's plan to foment terrorism and prop up fundamentalist forces.

'The R&AW should have known about the ISI and the entire terror plot.' Mirza looked at Ashfaq in surprise.

'We know raising jihadis is still a standing order for the ISI and they are making every possible effort to take over Afghanistan through terror proxies, but we are doing whatever we can by providing evidence to the US and other countries,' said Ashfaq.